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NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister



DRIVING FORCE

From leading the government's effort to make India self-reliant to being the BJP's trump card in electoral politics, Modi was a formidable force to be reckoned with in 2022

By Anilesh S. Mahajan

It speaks of a man's creativity with the self that he continues to make and define news 20 years after he first burst on the national consciousness. Narendra Modi has done this because he has continued to evolve, both in his politics and his policymaking. In his prime ministerial role, he casts a very wide net—right from his understanding of local-level minutiae to global statesmanship. The first aspect allows him to continue being the BJP's prime vote-getter and mascot. The way he powered his party to landslide majorities in Uttar Pradesh and his home state Gujarat is perhaps unmatched by any political personality. Yes, there have been setbacks too for the party—just this year saw two electoral defeats, in Himachal Pradesh and Punjab—but somehow his personal charisma and public stature seem immune to eclipse.

But the second aspect is the one that allows him to focus on the big picture with maturity and vision. India's economy remains among the most robust in the world because of the way he handled the darkness of Covid-19—a bold budget that committed serious money on infrastructure and public spending lays the foundation for future growth, and at a time when demand is sluggish and diminished animal spirits define the private sector. This is while seeking to restore market sentiments through the production-linked incentives (PLI) that he rolled out. The PLI scheme is being extended to sector after sector to help enable backward integration of supply chains. Signals are that 2023, which will see the last full budget of Modi's second tenure, will focus on imparting a massive boost to domestic consumption.

It will not be easy in times when emerging economies the world over are suffering, with a K-type recovery being witnessed after the pandemic's last wave. Populations at the bottom of the pyramid are feeling left out. It was this theme that Modi touched on in Bali as he accepted India's presidency of G20—talking about reorienting globalisation to make it inclusive and participatory. Even advanced economies faltered in their pandemic policy, but India saved itself through some sagacious moves by the Modi regime—focusing on creating long-term value via infrastructure rather than pumping money into the economy. On December 25, in the last episode of his radio show this year, *Mann ki Baat*, Modi underscored the reasons that made 2022 "wonderful". Making India move towards *atmanirbharta* (self-reliance) as a mantra for economic revival has started having an effect, with signs of green shoots. This gives him genuine stature across the globe, lending a touch of lustre to his presidency of G20.

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The trade deals he has struck with the UAE and Australia similarly go towards